

Evaluating Dark Patterns in Amazon's Subscription Process

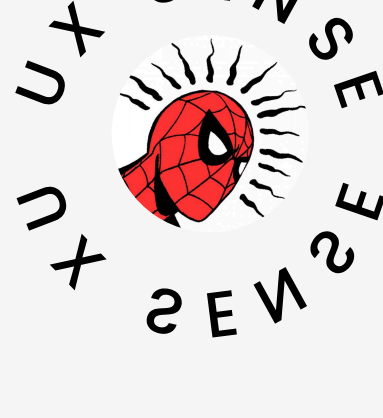
by Sanket Sawant

STORY TIME

So recently, a doctor prescribed my mom Vitamin C capsules. Naturally, we bought them from the medical store, But on a casual afternoon I was on my phone just browsing and you know how that product or thing you want to buy/bought suddenly starts showing in ads, I clicked on it by mistakenly and I noticed that

Subscribe and Save

"IS SELECTED BY DEFAULT!??"



and suddenly my UX sense tingled like,
"That's literally the definition of a dark pattern!"
Who wants yet another subscription?

ETHICAL INSIGHT

Dark Pattern – Defaults
"A Dark Pattern is a user interface that has been crafted to trick users into doing things, such as [signing up for recurring bills] instead, aim to build a positive relationship between you and your users. If you want to change behaviors, do it with their consent."

[Brignull, Dark Patterns (2010)]



So put on my thinking hat and started to dig in deep, there's a lot to unpack here...

There are

4 psychology principles

used in this screen

1. Anchoring

to remind us that each pill is VERY cheap compared to the overall price.

2. The Endowment

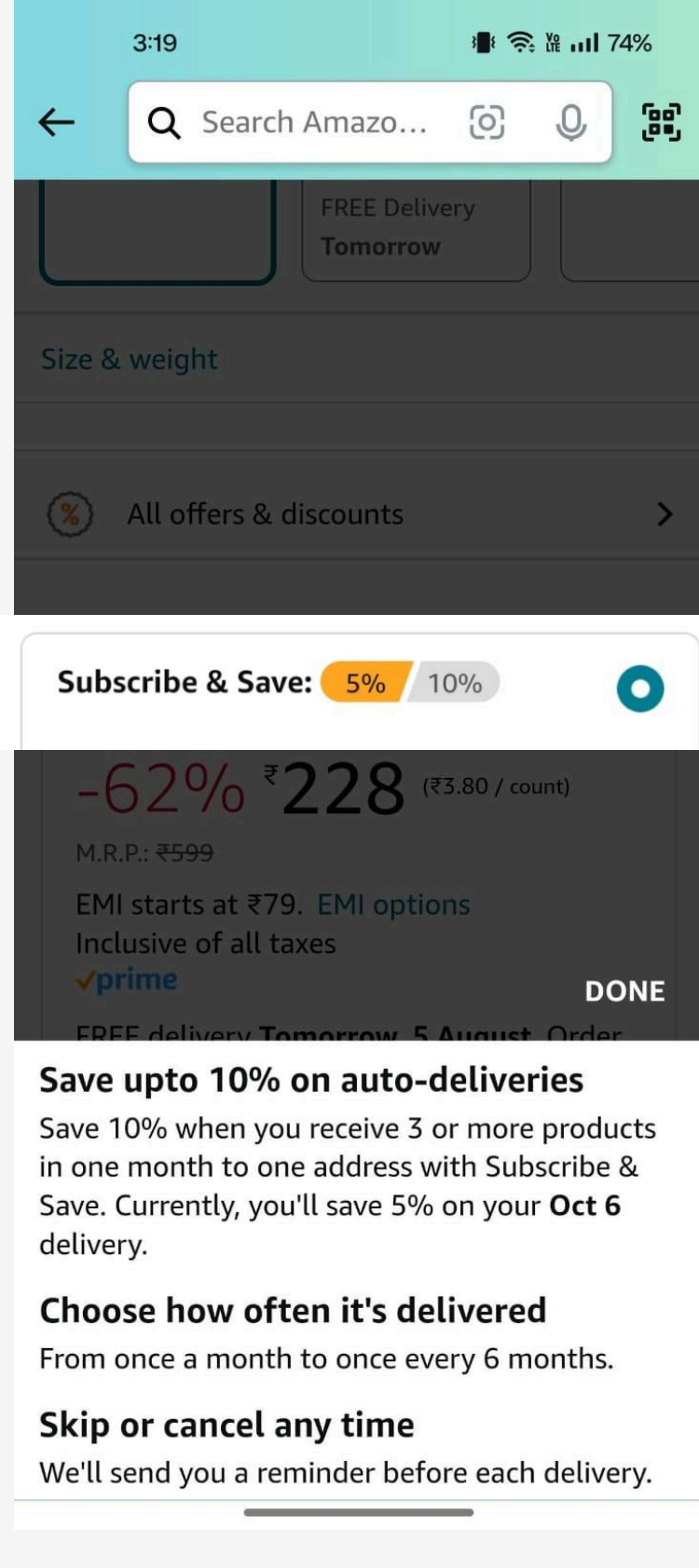
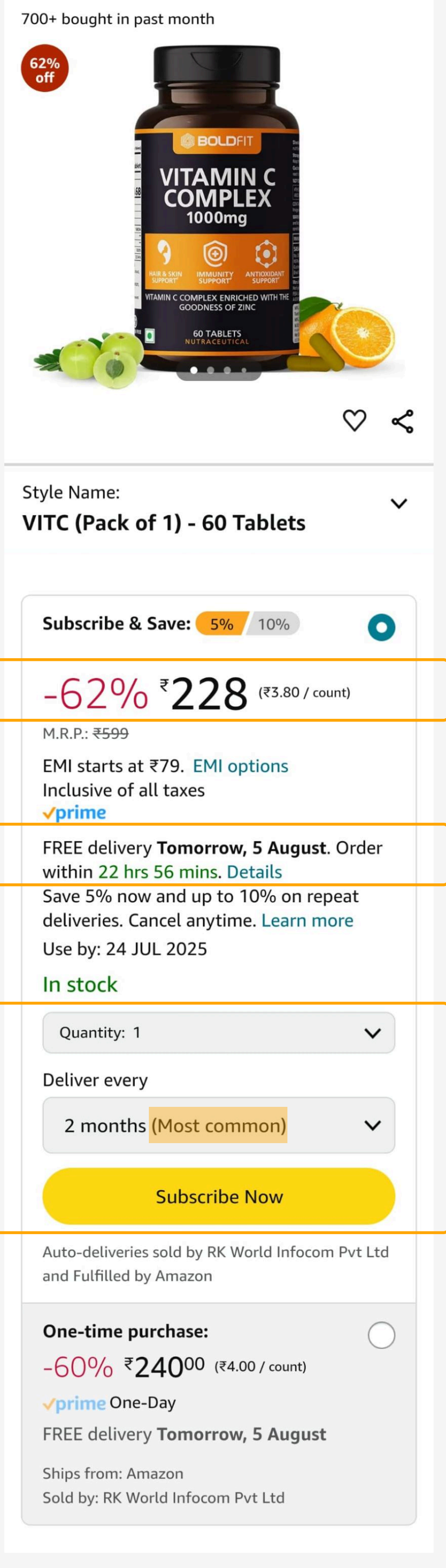
to make us feel like it's almost ours: "Get it Tomorrow."

3. Fitt's Law

to focus your attention directly on your subscription settings

4. Social Proof

to help you choose the "MOST COMMON" option for delivery frequency...



BUT there is one more interesting thing here

We must admit... 10% saving is interesting

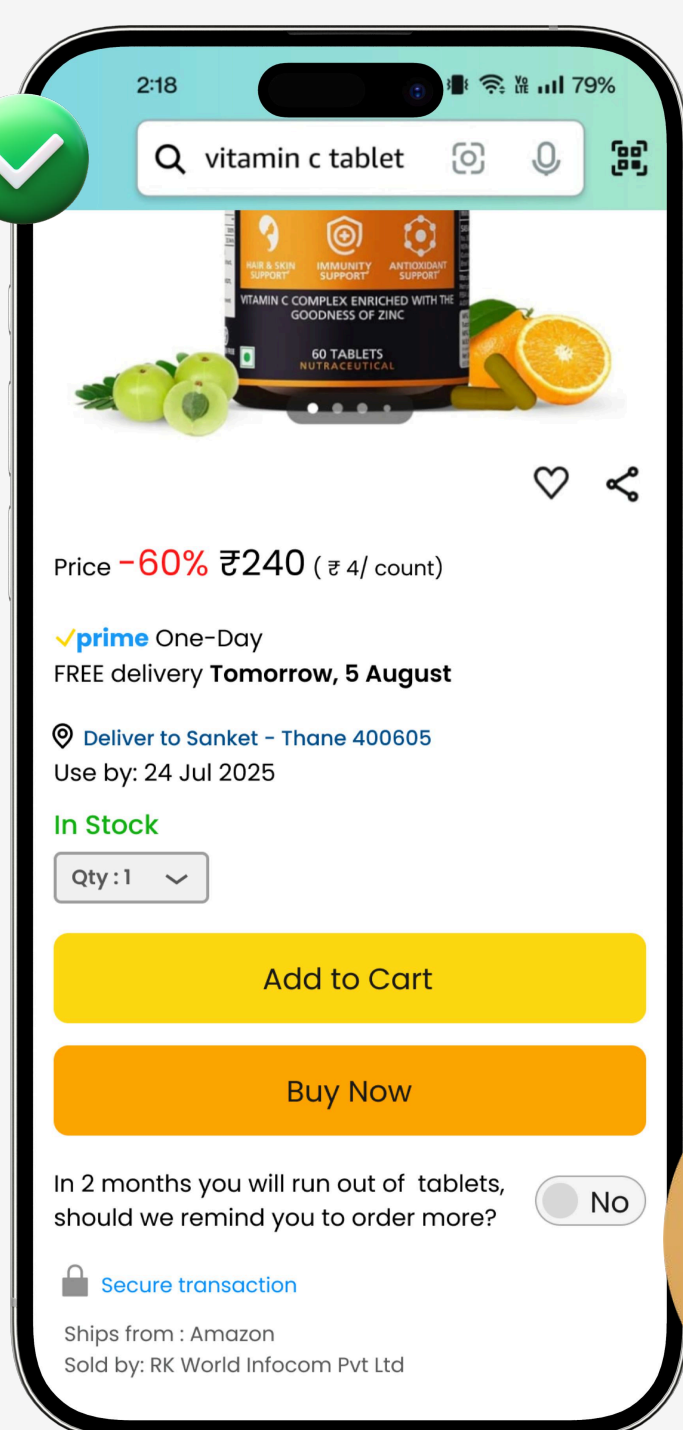
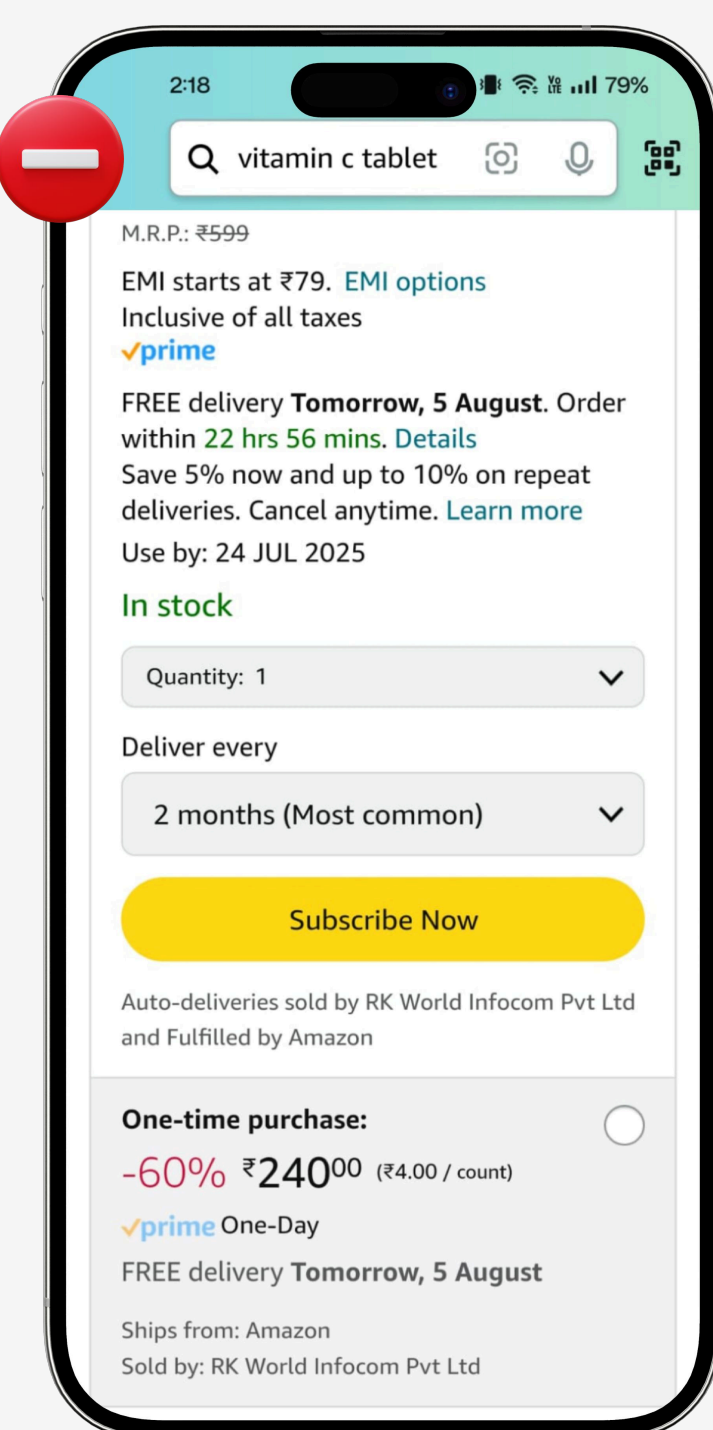
BUT returns

you need at least 5 subscriptions to get it...



Ufff.. such sneaky work amazon nice

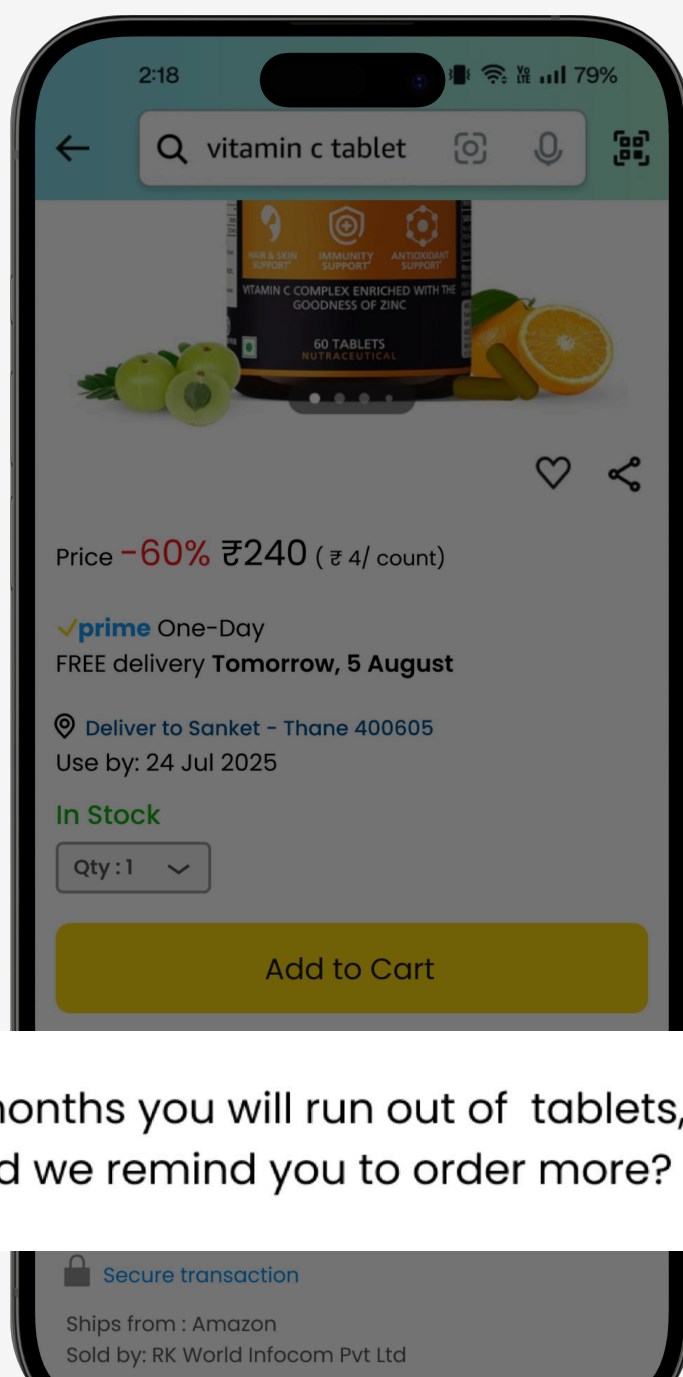
we identified the problem now let's see the solution
let's make this interaction less manipulative and ETHICAL



We applied 1 psychology principle to make this experience more ethical...

Self-initiated triggers

to increase chances of action when the reminder comes in.



In 2 months you will run out of tablets, should we remind you to order more?



Balancing Ethics and Practicality



Now, you might be thinking, "Come on, Sanket, they have to do their business! You're almost cutting their legs off!"

I KNOWWW (Monica Geller style)

But think about the brighter side. This approach might not increase short-term revenues, but it builds long-term trust. And Amazon, more than anything, needs to gain and maintain user trust.

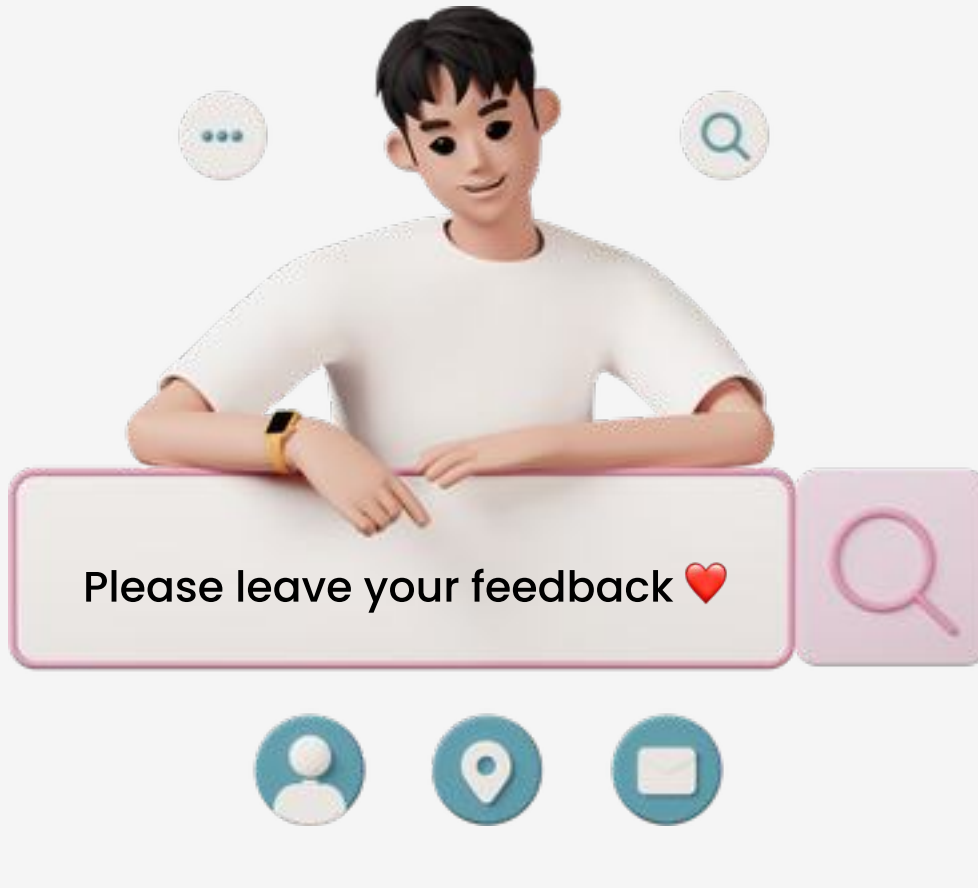
So it's a WIN-WIN

CONCLUSION

Hushhhhh... Simple curiosity led me to uncover the intricacies of dark patterns in UX design.

Who knew that simple curiosity would lead me to a UX case study? By addressing these dark patterns and applying ethical design principles, we can create a user experience that is not only effective but also respectful of the users' autonomy and trust.

Thank you for scrolling, it was short yet fun case study right? The detailed one will come soon, stay tuned



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